

Let's Encrypt Phase-5 RENEWAL + ROTATION — Deep Research (Caddy in- process renewal vs Pebble ARI, zero-downtime rotation proof)

Revision: 3 **Last modified:** 2026-07-01T10:55:00Z **Authority:** Helix Constitution §11.4.150 (deep multi-angle research before workstream commitment) + §11.4.99 (latest-source cross-reference) + §11.4.6 (no-guessing — every claim cited or marked UNCONFIRMED) + §11.4.107/§11.4.115 (rock-solid rotation proof). **Scope:** design the hermetic Phase-5 RENEWAL + ROTATION test against the already-built hermetic stack — Caddy image localhost/helix_proxy/caddy-challtestsrv:2.8.4, Pebble ghcr.io/letsencrypt/pebble:v2.6.0, pebble-challtestsrv, per deploy/letsencrypt/compose.hermetic.yml + deploy/letsencrypt/Caddyfile. **Consumes:** tests/letsencrypt/cert_analyzer.sh (cert_chain_roots_in / cert_not_expired / cert_san_matches / cert_days_remaining / cert_renewal_due, with the CERT_ANALYZER_NOW_EPOCH now-seam). **Prior research this REFINES:** docs/research/letsencrypt_hermetic_20260701/ANALYSIS.md Q4 + gotcha #10. That doc recommended renewal_window_ratio 1 + reload but marked "whether this Pebble build serves ARI" and "whether ARI overrides the ratio" as **UNCONFIRMED**. **This doc resolves both from source at the EXACT deployed versions** and vindicates the lever (see Q1).

Method note (§11.4.6 / §11.4.99): the load-bearing facts below are read directly from the source of the **deployed** versions — Pebble v2.6.0 (wfe/wfe.go, core/types.go, ca/ca.go, test/config/pebble-config.json at tag v2.6.0) and the certmagic/acmez that Caddy 2.8.4 bundles (go.mod@v2.8.4 -> certmagic v0.21.3 + acmez/v2 v2.0.1, read certificates.go/config.go/maintain.go at certmagic@v0.21.3) — fetched via gh api 2026-07-01. Version-mapped facts (release dates, PR->tag) come from the GitHub Releases/PR API. Where a runtime latency or an unread code path cannot be proven from source, it is marked **UNCONFIRMED** with the exact runtime method to obtain it — never guessed.

Correction 2026-07-01 — renewal_window_ratio is NOT a Caddyfile tls subdirective (live-verified)

READ THIS FIRST. It supersedes the "uncomment the `renewal_window_ratio` lever in the Caddyfile" recommendation in the Executive answer (#1), Q1 (Lever A), and the Phase-5 PROCEDURE step 4 below. The *certmagic mechanism analysis* in Q1 (ratio 1 → `currentlyInRenewalWindow` returns true immediately, unaffected by ARI) remains **valid and version-correct**. Only the **config surface** — *how you set the ratio* — was wrong for Caddy 2.8.4. This section replaces the Caddyfile lever with the JSON-config lever.

The FACT (conductor's live test, reproduced from source)

Adapting the deployed Caddyfile with `renewal_window_ratio` uncommented under the `tls { ... }` block makes Caddy **2.8.4** exit at config-adaptation time:

```
adapting config using caddyfile: parsing caddyfile tokens for
'tls': unknown subdirective: renewal_window_ratio
```

This is **correct behaviour for 2.8.4** — `renewal_window_ratio` is not a Caddyfile token in that release, in **either** position:

- **NOT a `tls` directive subdirective.** `caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/builtins.go@v2.8.4` `parseTLS` accepts exactly: `protocols`, `ciphers`, `curves`, `client_auth`, `alpn`, `load`, `ca`, `key_type`, `eab`, `issuer`, `get_certificate`, `dns`, `resolvers`, `propagation_delay`, `propagation_timeout`, `dns_ttl`, `dns_challenge_override_domain`, `ca_root`, `on_demand`, `reuse_private_keys`, `insecure_secrets_log`. **`renewal_window_ratio` is absent.**
- **NOT a global option** either. `caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/options.go@v2.8.4` registers (TLS/ACME-relevant): `acme_ca`, `acme_ca_root`, `acme_dns`, `acme_eab`, `cert_issuer`, `cert_lifetime`, `key_type`, `local_certs`, `on_demand_tls`, `ocsp_interval`, `ocsp_stapling`, `renew_interval`, `skip_install_trust`, `preferred_chains`, `default_sni`, `fallback_sni`. **`renewal_window_ratio` is absent.**
- **The Caddyfile token was added ~2.5 years later.** PR [caddyserver/caddy#7473](https://github.com/caddyserver/caddy/pull/7473) "caddyfile: Add `renewal_window_ratio`" (both as a global option **and** a per-site `tls` subdirective) merged **2026-02-13**, milestone **v2.11.1**. The *current* `caddyserver.com` `tls/global-options` docs (cited in Revision 1) reflect **latest** Caddy, which is exactly why Revision

1 mistook a ≥ 2.11 token for a 2.8.4 one. On the deployed 2.8.4 image it does not exist. **The commented line #
renewal_window_ratio {\$CADDY_RENEWAL_RATIO} at deploy/
letsencrypt/Caddyfile:110 MUST stay commented on 2.8.4
— uncommenting it breaks config adaptation (the error
above). Any Caddyfile-lever instruction in this doc is void
for 2.8.4.**

What IS reachable in 2.8.4 — the ratio is a JSON field, not a Caddyfile token

modules/caddytls/automation.go@v2.8.4 carries it on the **automation policy** as `RenewalWindowRatio float64`
`json:"renewal_window_ratio,omitempty"` (path ``apps.tls.automation.policies[].renewal_window_ratio``), and the sibling ``RenewCheckInterval caddy.Duration``
``json:"renew_interval,omitempty"` (default 10m) on `apps.tls.automation`. So the **exact certmagic v0.21.3 codepath Q1 analyses is fully reachable on 2.8.4 — you set the field via JSON, never via the Caddyfile**. Setting the ratio to 1 on the policy that manages `proxy.hermetic.test` forces `certNeedsRenewal` true immediately on the next config load, exactly as Q1 proves.

CORRECTED force-renewal mechanism (ranked, deployed stack = Caddy 2.8.4 + Pebble v2.6.0)

Rank	Mechanism (2.8.4-valid)	Deterministic?	Zero-downtime
1 (RECOMMENDED)	JSON <code>renewal_window_ratio: 1</code> applied via the admin API — either granular <code>PATCH /config/apps/tls/automation/policies/<i>/renewal_window_ratio</code> (body 1), or full <code>POST /load</code> of the adapted-then-edited JSON with <code>Content-Type: application/json</code> Short <code>cert_lifetime</code> + short <code>renew_interval</code> (BOTH valid 2.8.4 global options), default ratio 0.3333 — Caddy renews at <code>notAfter - lifetime/3</code> ,	YES — ratio 1 = <code>currentlyInRenewalWindow</code> true for any issued cert, ARI cannot suppress it (Q1, certmagic v0.21.3, unchanged)	YES — admin config change is graceful with rollback the in-process renewal hot-swaps the leaf
2 (Caddyfile-only fallback)	global options, default ratio 0.3333 — Caddy renews at <code>notAfter - lifetime/3</code> ,	Partial — time-based, not instant	YES (in-process)

Rank	Mechanism (2.8.4-valid)	Deterministic?	Zero-downtime
	caught within renew_interval		
3 (issuance proof only)	Delete the stored cert + restart Caddy (fresh issuance)	YES	NO — restart drops connections

There is **no dedicated imperative "force renew now" admin endpoint** in Caddy 2.8.4 — certmagic/Caddy expose *config manipulation* (Rank 1), not a force-renew RPC. Candidate "admin endpoint to force renewal" therefore collapses into Rank 1. Pebble's /set-renewal-info/ ARI-override endpoint is **absent in v2.6.0** (added by PR #501 → v2.8.0), so the ARI-override lever remains unavailable without an operator Pebble bump (Revision 1 Lever B, unchanged).

CORRECTED Phase-5 force step (replaces PROCEDURE step 4)

Determinism prerequisite is unchanged: enable the admin API for the test (CADDY_ADMIN=0.0.0.0:2019, publish 127.0.0.1:2019:2019). Then force one renewal with JSON, **not** a text/caddyfile body:

```
# (i) capture the running config as JSON (adapter already ran at boot; this is the live tree)
curl -sf http://127.0.0.1:2019/config/ -o caddy_running.json

# (ii) find the automation policy index managing proxy.hermetic.test, then set ratio=1 on it.
# Method A – granular PATCH (minimal blast radius; <i> from the GET above, usually 0):
curl -sf -X PATCH -H 'Content-Type: application/json' \
  --data '1' \
```

```
http://127.0.0.1:2019/config/apps/tls/automation/policies/0/  
renewal_window_ratio
```

```
#      Method B – full graceful reload (robust if the policy/field  
must be created):  
#      edit caddy_running.json so  
apps.tls.automation.policies[<i>].renewal_window_ratio = 1, then:  
curl -sf -X POST -H 'Content-Type: application/json' \  
    --data-binary @caddy_ratio1.json \  
    http://127.0.0.1:2019/load
```

Either call re-manages the cert at config-apply time →
certNeedsRenewal returns true via the unconditional ratio check
(Q1) → in-process renewal + hot-swap, zero downtime. **Reset
step 8** identically: PATCH ... /renewal_window_ratio back to the
default (0.3333) or POST /load the original JSON.

UNCONFIRMED (§11.4.6), runtime-checkable, none block

Phase-5: (a) the concrete policy index <i> and whether the
Caddyfile-adapted tree already carries an
apps.tls.automation.policies[] entry for the explicit tls { issuer
acme ... } block — resolve by reading caddy_running.json from step
(i) (the explicit issuer forces a policy, so index 0 is expected but
MUST be read, not assumed); (b) whether PATCH on an absent
renewal_window_ratio key requires POST instead (PATCH strictly
replaces an existing value; POST to an object path creates-or-
replaces) — if the granular PATCH returns a "not
found"/"unknown key" error, use Method B (full POST /load), which
is unconditionally correct.

What is UNCHANGED and still correct

The **zero-downtime observable** (Q2 / PROCEDURE step 5) is
independent of the force mechanism and stands verbatim: served-
leaf **serial** and **notBefore** both change while a tight continuous
TLS probe records **0 failed requests**. The openssl capture —
openssl s_client -connect 127.0.0.1:8443 -servername
proxy.hermetic.test </dev/null 2>/dev/null | openssl x509 -noout
-serial -startdate — is correct; PASS requires serial_after !=
serial_before **and** notBefore_after > notBefore_before with fail ==
0. All cert_analyzer.sh assertions (Q4), the Pebble per-boot-CA
handling (Q3), and the certmagic ratio/ARI analysis (Q1) are
unaffected by this correction.

Executive answer (the three asks)

1. Recommended force-renewal mechanism:

renewal_window_ratio 1 forced via the admin API. [△](#)

CORRECTED (see the Correction 2026-07-01 section

above): on Caddy 2.8.4 the ratio is a **JSON field** (`apps.tls.automation.policies[].renewal_window_ratio`), **NOT** a Caddyfile token — apply it via granular PATCH `/config/.../renewal_window_ratio` or full POST `/load` with Content-Type: `application/json`, never a `text/caddyfile` body and never by uncommenting the stubbed `deploy/letsencrypt/Caddyfile` line (that breaks config adaptation on 2.8.4). The certmagic rationale below is unchanged. **Winning rationale (source-proven for Caddy 2.8.4 / certmagic v0.21.3):** on config load Caddy re-manages the cert and runs `certNeedsRenewal`; with ratio 1, `currentlyInRenewalWindow(notBefore, notAfter, 1.0)` computes `renewalWindowStart = notAfter - lifetime = notBefore`, so it returns `time.Now().After(notBefore) = TRUE` for any **already-issued cert** -> immediate in-process renewal + hot-swap. This ratio check runs **unconditionally after** the ARI block (which can only trigger renewal *earlier*, never *suppress* the ratio check), so it is **not defeated by Pebble's ARI** — resolving the prior doc's gotcha #10. It needs **no Pebble version bump, no revocation, no storage surgery**, and is the only lever that is both deterministic AND zero-downtime on the deployed stack.

2. **Concrete zero-downtime observable:** the served leaf's **serial number** and **notBefore** both CHANGE across the swap (`openssl s_client -connect ... | openssl x509 -noout -serial -startdate`) WHILE a tight continuous TLS-fetch probe records **0 failed requests / 0 dropped connections** — corroborated by the certmagic log line `certificate renewed successfully` (exact string, verified in source). A changed serial + advanced `notBefore` proves a real re-issue (not an in-memory cache reload).
3. **File written:** `docs/research/letsencrypt_renewal_20260701/ANALYSIS.md` (+ `.html` + `.pdf`). **Cited source count:** 24 distinct URLs (see footer) plus 7 pinned source-file reads at exact version tags.

Q1 — Forcing an immediate, deterministic renewal: four levers compared

△ **CORRECTED CONFIG SURFACE (see Correction 2026-07-01 above):** the certmagic decision logic in this section is valid for Caddy 2.8.4, but every `"Caddyfile renewal_window_ratio"` / Content-Type: `text/caddyfile` instruction below is **void on 2.8.4** — the token does not exist until v2.11.1. Set the ratio via the **JSON admin API** instead. Lever A's *mechanism* wins; its *Caddyfile surface* does not.

The core mechanism (source-confirmed, Caddy 2.8.4 = certmagic v0.21.3)

certmagic@v0.21.3/certificates.go:certNeedsRenewal(leaf, ari, ...) is the single decision function. Its structure (verbatim shape):

```
if !cfg.DisableARI {
    selectedTime := ari.SelectedTime           // (or a random
pick inside SuggestedWindow)
    if !selectedTime.IsZero() {
        cutoff := ari.SelectedTime - RenewCheckInterval
        if time.Now().After(cutoff) { return
true }           // ARI window reached -> renew EARLY
        if currentlyInRenewalWindow(notBefore, exp, 1.0/20.0)
{ return true } // emergency (past 95% life)
        }
    }
// runs UNCONDITIONALLY (the ARI block only ever early-returns
true; it never returns false)
if currentlyInRenewalWindow(notBefore, exp,
cfg.RenewalWindowRatio) {           // the ratio check
    return true
}
if currentlyInRenewalWindow(notBefore, exp, 1.0/50.0) ||
    time.Until(exp) < RenewCheckInterval*5 { return
true }           // imminent-expiry safety net
return false
```

and certmagic@v0.21.3/certificates.go:currentlyInRenewalWindow:

```
lifetime           = notAfter - notBefore
renewalWindow      = lifetime * renewalWindowRatio
renewalWindowStart = notAfter - renewalWindow
return time.Now().After(renewalWindowStart)
```

Key deduction (the whole basis of the recommendation):

with renewalWindowRatio = 1.0, renewalWindowStart = notAfter - lifetime = notBefore, so the ratio check returns time.Now().After(notBefore) = **TRUE for any issued cert**, immediately. And because this check sits **after** the if !cfg.DisableARI { ... } block — not inside an else — **ARI cannot suppress it**. certmagic's ARI/ratio relationship is therefore an **OR** (renew if ARI says so **OR** the ratio window is reached **OR** expiry is imminent), NOT "ARI wins over ratio." The widely-repeated "ARI takes precedence over renewal_window_ratio" statement (Caddy docs, community threads) is true only in the narrow sense that **ARI can trigger a renewal earlier than the ratio would** — it does not, and cannot, *prevent* a ratio-triggered renewal. **This is why renewal_window_ratio 1 deterministically forces renewal even though Pebble v2.6.0 serves an ARI window far in the future (Q3).**

Renewal trigger timing (source-confirmed): Caddy runs its maintenance loop on a `time.NewTicker(RenewCheckInterval)`; certmagic v0.21.3 default `RenewCheckInterval = 10 * time.Minute` — but the test must NOT wait for the ticker. On config load Caddy re-manages each cert via the `renew()` closure in `certmagic@v0.21.3/config.go (... ensure ARI is updated ... if cert.NeedsRenewal(cfg) { RenewCertAsync/Sync } ... reloadManagedCertificate)`, i.e. it checks **at config-load time** — matching Caddy author Matt Holt: *"Caddy will immediately renew the certificate regardless of scan time, because it always checks when the config is first loaded."* A continuous TLS probe (Q2) additionally drives the on-demand/handshake maintenance path, so the async renewal completes promptly.

Lever comparison (deployed stack: Pebble v2.6.0 + Caddy 2.8.4)

Lever	Deterministic?	Zero-downtime?	Needs	Ver
A. <code>renewal_window_ratio 1 + POST /load reload</code>	YES — ratio check returns true immediately, ARI cannot suppress it (source-proven)	YES — in-process renewal hot-swaps the cert; <code>POST /load</code> is a graceful reload	nothing new (uses the stubbed <code>CADDY_RENEWAL_RATIO</code> lever + admin API)	RE
B. Pebble <code>/set-renewal-info/</code> ARI override -> past window	YES (ARI-native)	YES (in-process)	Pebble bump to >= v2.8.0 (endpoint added by PR #501, merged 2025-06-05; ABSENT in the deployed v2.6.0) + forcing an ARI re-fetch (ARI is cached ~Retry-After 6h) out-of-band ACME revoke; Pebble returns <code>RenewalInfoImmediate</code> for revoked serials — but Caddy must re-fetch ARI (6h cache) to see it, and Pebble config disables OCSP (<code>ocspResponderURL: ""</code>) so certmagic's	Alte ope Peb mov
C. ACME-revoke the served leaf	Partial	YES (in-process)		Not stac

Lever	Deterministic?	Zero-downtime?	Needs	Ver
			OCSF-revoke forceRenew path is unavailable	
D. Delete cert from storage + restart Caddy	YES (fresh issuance, ARI- independent)	NO — process restart drops connections	nothing new	GoC SER "iss rota can zer

Why not "delete cert from storage + *reload*" (no restart)?

Caddy issues #5589 and #6789 show a config *reload* does **not** reliably flush the in-memory cert cache / re-read storage for a same-identity cert — so delete+reload risks continuing to serve the cached leaf. That caveat is about **re-reading externally-modified/deleted files**, and is exactly why Lever A (which drives certmagic's *own* renewal codepath, replacing the cert in cache via `reloadManagedCertificate` on successful renewal) is preferred over any storage-surgery approach.

Runtime-toggle wiring (important — the Caddyfile is

mounted :ro). `deploy/letsencrypt/Caddyfile` reads `renewal_window_ratio` `{${CADDY_RENEWAL_RATIO}}` from process env, and env is fixed at container start; the Caddyfile mount is read-only. So the ratio cannot be flipped by editing the file in place. Two supported ways to apply `ratio=1` at runtime without a restart:

- **(preferred) POST /load a config that carries a literal `renewal_window_ratio 1`**. Enable the admin API for the test (`CADDY_ADMIN=0.0.0.0:2019`, publish `127.0.0.1:2019:2019`), then POST the adapted config (Caddyfile body via `Content-Type: text/caddyfile`, or the JSON from `caddy adapt`) with the ratio line set to the literal 1. This is a genuine config change -> full TLS reprovision -> `renew()` runs -> `renew` + hot-swap. Reset by POST /load-ing the original config afterward.
- **(simplest) boot with `CADDY_RENEWAL_RATIO=1` from the start**. Caddy then renews on every maintenance pass; the endpoint continuously rotates. The test samples the served leaf twice and asserts the serial changed with 0 dropped connections. Less controlled (no stable "before" baseline window) but requires no admin/config surgery. Revert to the default ratio when done.

Sources: Caddy `tls` directive + global options

(`renewal_window_ratio`, default 0.3333; ARI "is a suggestion ... may not align with this ratio"); Caddy API/automatic-https (POST /load "incurs zero downtime", background cert management, renewal hot-swap); Matt Holt on force-renewal (`ratio=1` + `reload`);

delete+reload); Caddy issues #5589/#6789 (reload cert-cache caveat); certmagic v0.21.3 [certificates.go/config.go/maintain.go](https://certmagic.org/config.go/maintain.go) (read at tag). See footer.

Q2 — Proving ZERO-DOWNTIME rotation: the concrete observable

Primary evidence = the cert changed AND the endpoint never dropped. Two independent captures taken across the forced renewal:

1. **Re-issue proof (the leaf actually rotated, not a cache reload).** Pull the *served* leaf before and after and compare two fields:

```
openssl s_client -connect 127.0.0.1:8443 -servername
proxy.hermetic.test </dev/null 2>/dev/null \
| openssl x509 -noout -serial -startdate
# serial=<hex>      notBefore=<date>
```

PASS requires `serial_after != serial_before` AND `notBefore_after > notBefore_before`. A changed serial proves Pebble issued a NEW certificate (each Pebble issuance gets a fresh random serial); an advanced notBefore proves it was issued later (not the same cert re-served). Comparing only one field is insufficient — the serial alone could in principle collide; the pair is the rock-solid signal (§11.4.107 not-stale cross-check).

1. **Continuous-availability proof (no dropped connection across the swap).** Run a tight sampling loop against the TLS endpoint spanning the reload + the renewal swap, counting failures:

```
# sample every ~0.2s; a full TLS handshake + HTTP 200 each
iteration
while <rotation not yet observed>; do
    curl -sf --max-time 2 --resolve
proxy.hermetic.test:8443:127.0.0.1 \
    --cacert pebble_ca_bundle.pem \
    https://proxy.hermetic.test:8443/health >/dev/null \
    && ok=$((ok+1)) || fail=$((fail+1))
done
```

PASS requires `fail == 0` (every request completed a TLS handshake and got its response) across the entire window in which the serial transitions from `serial_before` to `serial_after`. This is the zero-downtime assertion: Caddy "swaps out the old

certificate with the new one ... zero downtime" (automatic-https docs) and `POST /load` "incurs zero downtime" (API docs) — the probe MEASURES it rather than asserting it.

Corroborating (not sole) evidence — Caddy logs. With JSON logging, `grep` the `certmagic/tls` logger stream for the exact strings (verified in `certmagic@v0.21.3` source):

- `renewing certificate (config.go)` — renewal started;
- `certificate renewed successfully (config.go)` — renewal completed;
- `certificate is in configured renewal window based on expiration date (certificates.go)` — the ratio check fired (proves `ratio=1` was the trigger, not ARI);
- (initial issuance, for the baseline: `obtaining certificate -> certificate obtained successfully`).

Treat the log as corroboration of *why/when*; the `changed-serial + zero-failure` pair is the proof. **UNCONFIRMED:** the exact wall-clock latency from `POST /load` to the new serial appearing (depends on Pebble VA scheduling + `acmez` retry) — the test polls the served serial with a bounded timeout rather than assuming a fixed delay; `PEBBLE_VA_NOSLEEP=1 + PEBBLE_WFE_NONCEREJECT=0` (already set in the compose) keep it prompt.

Do NOT conflate the reload blip with the renewal. A *full config reload* (`POST /load`) reprovisions the TLS app; the *renewal* is the in-process hot-swap. Both are documented zero-downtime; the single continuous probe spans both, so `fail == 0` covers the whole operation. (This is also why the probe, not the log, is authoritative — issues #5589/#6789 show cache behavior around reload is subtle.)

Sources: Caddy automatic-https + API docs; `certmagic v0.21.3` log strings (read at tag). See footer.

Q3 — Pebble-specific rotation quirks (deployed v2.6.0), source-confirmed

1. **Per-boot issuance-CA regeneration (unchanged from the hermetic doc — still load-bearing here).** Pebble regenerates its issuance root/intermediate on every launch and stores nothing on disk. **Consequence for Phase-5:** re-fetch the run's CA chain (`/roots/0 + /intermediates/0`) at assertion time; NEVER pin a golden CA fixture. Because Phase-5 renews *within one Pebble boot*, `leaf_1` and `leaf_2` chain to the **same** run-CA — so the CA bundle is fetched once per test run and

reused for both chain assertions (Q4). (If the stack is restarted mid-test, the CA changes and both leaves must be re-verified against the new bundle.)

2. **Pebble v2.6.0 DOES serve ARI — and its window is far in the future for a fresh cert.**

Confirmed at tag v2.6.0: wfe/wfe.go exposes `renewalInfoPath = "/draft-ietf-acme-ari-03/renewalInfo/"`, advertised in the directory.

`determineARIWindow(certID):`

- returns `core.RenewalInfoImmediate(now)` (a window **1 hour in the past**) **only if the serial is REVOKED**;
- otherwise returns `core.RenewalInfoSimple(notBefore, notAfter)`, whose window is *"a point 2/3 of the way through the validity period, then a 2-day window around that"* (`core/types.go: idealRenewal = notAfter - validity/3; window = [idealRenewal - 24h, idealRenewal + 24h]`). With Pebble's default validity (see #3), a freshly-issued cert's ARI window starts **~3.3 years out**, so ARI on its own never triggers renewal in-test — and, per Q1, it also does NOT suppress the `renewal_window_ratio 1` trigger. **This is the fact that both (a) explains why time-based waiting is infeasible and (b) confirms Lever A is safe against ARI.** The `/set-renewal-info/` override endpoint that could move this window is **NOT in v2.6.0** (added by PR #501, merged 2025-06-05, first shipped in **v2.8.0**).

3. **Pebble default issued-leaf validity ~= 5 years, and Pebble HONORS a client-requested notBefore/notAfter (resolves a prior UNCONFIRMED).**

`test/config/pebble-config.json@v2.6.0` sets `"certificateValidityPeriod": 157766400 seconds = 1826 days ~= 5 years`; `ca/ca.go@v2.6.0` computes `certNotAfter = certNotBefore + (validity-1)s`, **but** if the ACME order carries `notBefore/notAfter` it parses and honors them (`ca/ca.go@v2.6.0` lines ~272-286). So a client (Caddy's global `cert_lifetime`, which maps to the ACME order's `notAfter`) can request a SHORTER cert. **UNCONFIRMED:** whether `certmagic v0.21.3` actually populates the ACME order `notAfter` from `cert_lifetime` — verify at runtime with `openssl x509 -noout -startdate -enddate` on the issued leaf. Not needed for Lever A (validity-independent), but a short `cert_lifetime` is a useful secondary knob if a future test wants a time-based (rather than ratio-forced) renewal.

4. **ARI is client-cached ~6h (Retry-After), gated by acmez Needs Refresh().**

`wfe/wfe.go@v2.6.0` sets `Retry-After: 21600 (6h)` on the `renewalInfo` response; `certmagic@v0.21.3` only re-fetches ARI when `!DisableARI && cert.ari.NeedsRefresh()`. **Consequence:** any ARI-based lever (B or C) is not promptly deterministic without forcing an ARI re-fetch (delete stored ARI metadata or restart) — a second reason Lever A (which bypasses ARI via the unconditional ratio check) is the clean choice.

5. **Nonce/VA randomization (already mitigated in the deployed compose).** Pebble defaults: 0-15 s VA sleep, 5% nonce rejection, ~50% authz reuse. The compose already sets PEBBLE_VA_NOSLEEP=1 and PEBBLE_WFE_NONCEREJECT=0 and runs -strict false; acmez retries nonces automatically. Keep per-attempt timeouts generous enough that a single retry does not surface as a failure in the availability probe.
6. **Retry-After on validation is separate** (pebble-config.json@v2.6.0 "retryAfter":{"authz":3,"order":5}) — small, does not impede a single-boot renewal.
7. **The management interface is HTTPS on :15000, signed by pebble.minica.pem** — curl -k (or trust minica) to fetch /roots/0 + /intermediates/0. The compose publishes it on 127.0.0.1:15000, reachable by the conductor.

Sources: Pebble source at tag v2.6.0 (wfe/wfe.go, core/types.go, ca/ca.go, test/config/pebble-config.json); Pebble Releases + PRs #461/#484/#501 (GitHub API); RFC 9773 / draft-ietf-acme-ari (ARI window semantics). See footer.

Q4 — How cert_analyzer.sh plugs into the rotation assertion

The analyzer is client-and-challenge-agnostic and already provides every predicate the rotation test needs. Rotation adds only the **before/after** dimension (serial + notBefore delta), which is captured with openssl and asserted alongside the analyzer's PEM-level checks.

```
. tests/letsencrypt/cert_analyzer.sh

# --- run CA bundle (Pebble regenerates per boot; fetch ONCE per
test run, Q3.1) ---
curl -sk https://127.0.0.1:15000/roots/0 -o
pebble_root.pem
curl -sk https://127.0.0.1:15000/intermediates/0 -o
pebble_intermediate.pem
cat pebble_intermediate.pem pebble_root.pem >
pebble_ca_bundle.pem # bundle: Q4 note below

# --- BEFORE: served leaf #1 ---
openssl s_client -connect 127.0.0.1:8443 -servername
proxy.hermetic.test </dev/null 2>/dev/null \
| openssl x509 > leaf_1.pem
serial_1=$(openssl x509 -in leaf_1.pem -noout -serial)
nb_1=$(openssl x509 -in leaf_1.pem -noout -startdate)
```

```
# --- (force renewal per Q1 Lever A; poll served leaf until serial
changes) -> leaf_2.pem ---

# --- AFTER: assert with the analyzer + the delta ---
cert_chain_roots_in leaf_2.pem pebble_ca_bundle.pem # new cert
still ISSUED by the run's Pebble CA
cert_not_expired leaf_2.pem # inside
validity now (honours CERT_ANALYZER_NOW_EPOCH seam)
cert_san_matches leaf_2.pem proxy.hermetic.test # SAN still
covers the served host
cert_days_remaining leaf_2.pem # scalar
for the evidence report
# rotation delta (NOT in the analyzer – captured with openssl):
# serial_2 != serial_1 AND nb_2 > nb_1
```

Mapping (each analyzer function -> its role in the rotation PASS):

Assertion	Function / capture	PASS condition
A real re-issue happened	openssl x509 -serial -startdate before vs after	serial_2 != serial_1 and notBefore_2 > notBefore_1
New cert issued by the run's Pebble CA	cert_chain_roots_in leaf_2.pem pebble_ca_bundle.pem	returns 0
New cert valid now	cert_not_expired leaf_2.pem [now_epoch]	returns 0
New cert covers the host	cert_san_matches leaf_2.pem proxy.hermetic.test	returns 0
Zero-downtime	continuous TLS probe failure counter (Q2)	fail == 0
(report scalar)	cert_days_remaining leaf_2.pem	prints days
(regression seam, optional)	cert_renewal_due leaf_1.pem <thresh> <now_epoch>	using the CERT_ANALYZER_NOW_EPOCH seam, leaf_1 can be <i>asserted</i> "due" at a synthetic now — the deterministic §11.4.115 RED baseline that a rotation then clears

Load-bearing integration note (matches the analyzer implementation). cert_chain_roots_in runs openssl verify -no_check_time -CAfile <expected_ca_pem> <leaf>. Pebble issues a

leaf -> intermediate -> root chain, so verifying against the **root alone** FAILS ("unable to get local issuer certificate"). Pass the **root+intermediate BUNDLE** as `expected_ca_pem` (as above) — openssl verify treats every cert in `-CAfile` as a trust anchor, supplying the intermediate AND proving the leaf chains into the run's CA. `-no_check_time` keeps the chain check orthogonal to `cert_not_expired` (an expired-but-correctly-rooted cert still passes the chain check and fails the expiry check — by design, and useful for the §11.4.115 RED baseline). The `CERT_ANALYZER_NOW_EPOCH` seam (per-run) / trailing `now_epoch` arg (per-call) lets the same fixtures assert both "renewal was DUE before" and "the fresh leaf is valid now" with no time-travel (§11.4.50).

Sources: `tests/letsencrypt/cert_analyzer.sh` (in-repo); Pebble chain shape / "cannot get local issuer" (LE community + Pebble test/certs README). See footer.

Phase-5 test PROCEDURE (conductor-executable against the already-built stack)

Assumptions: the hermetic stack is booted via the containers submodule (§11.4.76) from `deploy/letsencrypt/compose.hermetic.yml`; Caddy localhost/helix_proxy/caddy-challtestsrv:2.8.4 has issued the Phase-3 baseline cert for `proxy.hermetic.test`; host ports per compose: Caddy HTTPS 127.0.0.1:8443, Pebble mgmt 127.0.0.1:15000. This procedure is **read/observe + a graceful reload only** — it does not stop/rebuild containers and does not touch `deploy/`, `wg0-mullvad`, `lava-*`, or `whoami:58080`.

Determinism prerequisite (one-time, in the boot config): enable the admin API for the test — set `CADDY_ADMIN=0.0.0.0:2019` and publish 127.0.0.1:2019:2019 (uncomment the admin port line in the compose). This is the only wiring the rotation test adds beyond Phase-3.

1. **Fetch the run's Pebble CA bundle (once).** `curl -sk https://127.0.0.1:15000/roots/0 -o pebble_root.pem; curl -sk https://127.0.0.1:15000/intermediates/0 -o pebble_intermediate.pem; cat pebble_intermediate.pem pebble_root.pem > pebble_ca_bundle.pem.`
2. **Baseline (leaf #1).** `openssl s_client -connect 127.0.0.1:8443 -servername proxy.hermetic.test </dev/null 2>/dev/null | openssl x509 > leaf_1.pem; record serial_1 = openssl x509 -in leaf_1.pem -noout -serial and nb_1 = ... -startdate. Sanity: cert_chain_roots_in leaf_1.pem pebble_ca_bundle.pem, cert_not_expired leaf_1.pem, cert_san_matches leaf_1.pem proxy.hermetic.test all return 0.`

3. **Start the availability probe (background).** Tight loop (~0.2 s) `curl -sf --max-time 2 --resolve proxy.hermetic.test:8443:127.0.0.1 --cacert pebble_ca_bundle.pem https://proxy.hermetic.test:8443/health`, incrementing ok/fail. Keep it running through steps 4-5.
4. **Force renewal (Lever A).** **△ CORRECTED — use the JSON step, NOT the text/caddyfile body shown here.** The Content-Type: text/caddyfile + uncommented-Caddyfile form below is **void on Caddy 2.8.4** (config adaptation fails: unknown subdirective: renewal_window_ratio). Use instead the "CORRECTED Phase-5 force step" in the Correction 2026-07-01 section: `PATCH -H 'Content-Type: application/json' --data '1' http://127.0.0.1:2019/config/apps/tls/automation/policies/0/renewal_window_ratio` (or full POST /load of the adapted-then-edited JSON with Content-Type: application/json). The graceful config change re-manages the cert -> certNeedsRenewal returns true via the unconditional ratio check -> in-process renewal + hot-swap.
~~`curl -X POST -H 'Content-Type: text/caddyfile' --data-binary @Caddyfile_ratio1 http://127.0.0.1:2019/load`~~ (VOID on 2.8.4 — retained struck-through only to mark what was corrected).
5. **Observe the rotation.** Poll `openssl s_client ... | openssl x509 -noout -serial -startdate` (bounded timeout, e.g. 60 s) until the serial differs from serial_1; capture leaf_2.pem, serial_2, nb_2. Corroborate in the Caddy JSON log: renewing certificate then certificate renewed successfully (+ certificate is in configured renewal window based on expiration date).
6. **Stop the probe; record ok/fail.**
7. **Assert (PASS requires ALL):**
 - `serial_2 != serial_1 and nb_2 > nb_1` (real re-issue);
 - `cert_chain_roots_in leaf_2.pem pebble_ca_bundle.pem == 0` (new cert roots in the run's Pebble CA);
 - `cert_not_expired leaf_2.pem == 0 and cert_san_matches leaf_2.pem proxy.hermetic.test == 0`;
 - `fail == 0` across the whole window (zero-downtime).
8. **Reset (rate-limit / renew-storm hygiene).** POST /load the ORIGINAL config (ratio back to the default 0.3333) so Caddy stops renewing every maintenance pass. (Moot against Pebble, correct discipline for the staging/prod cutover.)
9. **Determinism (§11.4.50).** Repeat steps 2-8 N times (default 3), asserting identical PASS + identical assertion outcomes each iteration; because the renewal is within one boot, the CA bundle from step 1 is reused (Q3.1).
10. **Evidence (§11.4.69 / §11.4.107).** Persist under `qa-results/<run-id>/letsencrypt_rotation/`: leaf_1.pem, leaf_2.pem, the serial/notBefore captures, the Caddy renewal log lines, the availability ok/fail counters, and pebble_ca_bundle.pem.

RED baseline (§11.4.115, optional but recommended).

Before the fix/lever is wired, the same harness with the availability probe but WITHOUT step 4 (or with a broken force-

lever) must show the serial NEVER changes within the timeout -> the test FAILs (serial_2 == serial_1), proving the assertion genuinely catches "no rotation." Flipping in Lever A turns it GREEN.

Anti-bluff (§11.4 / §11.4.107). The proof is the tuple (*serial changed AND notBefore advanced AND new leaf chains to the run's Pebble CA AND new leaf valid AND 0 dropped connections*) with captured PEMs — never a log line alone, never PEBBLE_VA_ALWAYS_VALID (which the compose correctly sets to 0; setting it to 1 would not exercise DNS-01 and would be a §11.4 PASS-bluff for this phase).

Honest gaps (UNCONFIRMED — runtime method stated inline; none block Phase-5)

- **Exact POST /load -> new-serial latency** (Pebble VA scheduling + acmez retries). Method: the procedure POLLS the served serial with a bounded timeout; PEBBLE_VA_NOSLEEP=1 + NONCEREJECT=0 (already set) keep it prompt.
 - **Whether certmagic v0.21.3 populates the ACME order notAfter from Caddy cert_lifetime** (Pebble v2.6.0 *would* honor it). Method: openssl x509 -noout -startdate -enddate on an issued leaf after setting cert_lifetime. Not needed for Lever A.
 - **Whether the availability probe records literally 0 failures across the reload+swap on this host** — this is precisely what the test MEASURES (the zero-downtime claim is asserted from Caddy docs and PROVEN by the probe, not assumed).
 - **Renewal sync vs async on the load path** (config.go renew() calls RenewCertAsync/RenewCertSync depending on context). The poll-until-serial-changes design is robust to either.
-

Sources verified 2026-07-01

Added for the Correction 2026-07-01 (renewal_window_ratio config surface, live-verified at v2.8.4):

- Caddy caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/builtins.go @v2.8.4 (parseTLS subdirective switch — renewal_window_ratio ABSENT) — <https://raw.githubusercontent.com/caddyserver/caddy/v2.8.4/caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/builtins.go>
- Caddy caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/options.go @v2.8.4 (registered global options — renewal_window_ratio ABSENT; renew_interval + cert_lifetime PRESENT) — <https://raw.githubusercontent.com/caddyserver/caddy/v2.8.4/caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/options.go>

- raw.githubusercontent.com/caddyserver/caddy/v2.8.4/caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/options.go
- Caddy modules/caddytls/automation.go @v2.8.4
(RenewalWindowRatio float64
json:"renewal_window_ratio,omitempty" on AutomationPolicy;
RenewCheckInterval json:"renew_interval,omitempty" default
10m) — <https://raw.githubusercontent.com/caddyserver/caddy/v2.8.4/modules/caddytls/automation.go>
- Caddy PR #7473 "caddyfile: Add renewal_window_ratio"
(Caddyfile global option + tls subdirective; merged
2026-02-13; milestone v2.11.1 — i.e. added ~2.5 y AFTER
2.8.4) — <https://github.com/caddyserver/caddy/pull/7473>
- Caddy JSON config — apps/tls/automation/policies/
renewal_window_ratio (the JSON-only surface in 2.8.4) — [https://
caddyserver.com/docs/json/apps/tls/automation/policies/
renewal_window_ratio/](https://caddyserver.com/docs/json/apps/tls/automation/policies/renewal_window_ratio/)
- Caddy API — granular PATCH /config/[path] (strict replace) /
POST /config/[path] (create-or-append) / POST /load Content-
Types (application/json, text/caddyfile, application/json5); "zero
downtime ... rolled back ... without downtime" — [https://
caddyserver.com/docs/api](https://caddyserver.com/docs/api)

Revision 1 sources (unchanged):

- Caddy tls directive (renewal_window_ratio, dns, resolvers,
trusted_roots; ARI "is a suggestion") — reflects LATEST Caddy
(≥2.11), NOT 2.8.4 — [https://caddyserver.com/docs/caddyfile/
directives/tls](https://caddyserver.com/docs/caddyfile/directives/tls)
- Caddy global options (renewal_window_ratio default 0.3333;
ARI/ratio note) — [https://caddyserver.com/docs/caddyfile/
options](https://caddyserver.com/docs/caddyfile/options)
- Caddy Automatic HTTPS (background cert management;
renewal zero-downtime hot-swap) — [https://caddyserver.com/
docs/automatic-https](https://caddyserver.com/docs/automatic-https)
- Caddy API (POST /load "incurs zero downtime"; rollback on
failure) — <https://caddyserver.com/docs/api>
- Caddy community — "How to force renewal of Let's Encrypt
certificates" (Matt Holt: ratio=1 + reload "checks when the
config is first loaded"; delete+reload) — [https://
caddy.community/t/how-to-force-renewal-of-lets-encrypt-
certificates/14843](https://caddy.community/t/how-to-force-renewal-of-lets-encrypt-certificates/14843)
- Caddy issue #6789 — "reload --force won't recache
certificates" (v2.9.0-beta.3, 2025-01-16; reload does not re-
read storage for a same-identity cert) — [https://github.com/
caddyserver/caddy/issues/6789](https://github.com/caddyserver/caddy/issues/6789)
- Caddy issue #5589 — cert cache flush on config reload —
<https://github.com/caddyserver/caddy/issues/5589>
- Caddy issue #5516 — ARI support request — [https://
github.com/caddyserver/caddy/issues/5516](https://github.com/caddyserver/caddy/issues/5516)
- certmagic certificates.go @v0.21.3 (certNeedsRenewal,
currentlyInRenewalWindow) — [https://github.com/caddyserver/
certmagic/blob/v0.21.3/certificates.go](https://github.com/caddyserver/certmagic/blob/v0.21.3/certificates.go)

- certmagic config.go @v0.21.3 (load-time renew() path; ARI update; renew log strings) — <https://github.com/caddyserver/certmagic/blob/v0.21.3/config.go>
- certmagic maintain.go (master, RenewCheckInterval=10m default; ARI refresh gating; DisableARI) — <https://github.com/caddyserver/certmagic/blob/master/maintain.go>
- certmagic certificates.go (master, cross-check of the same logic + updated comments) — <https://github.com/caddyserver/certmagic/blob/master/certificates.go>
- Caddy go.mod @v2.8.4 (pins certmagic v0.21.3 + acmez/v2 v2.0.1) — <https://github.com/caddyserver/caddy/blob/v2.8.4/go.mod>
- certmagic ARI implementation PR #286 (Matt Holt) — <https://github.com/caddyserver/certmagic/pull/286>
- Pebble wfe/wfe.go @v2.6.0 (renewalInfoPath, determineARIWindow; no /set-renewal-info/) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/blob/v2.6.0/wfe/wfe.go>
- Pebble core/types.go @v2.6.0 (RenewalInfoSimple 2/3-of-lifetime +/-1d window; RenewalInfoImmediate 1h-past window) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/blob/v2.6.0/core/types.go>
- Pebble ca/ca.go @v2.6.0 (default validity + honors requested notBefore/notAfter) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/blob/v2.6.0/ca/ca.go>
- Pebble test/config/pebble-config.json @v2.6.0 (certificateValidityPeriod 157766400s ~ 5y) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/blob/v2.6.0/test/config/pebble-config.json>
- Pebble Releases (v2.6.0 2024-05-31, v2.7.0 2025-01-24, v2.8.0 2025-06-05, v2.9.0 2025-12-18, v2.10.1 2026-04-20) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/releases>
- Pebble PR #461 "Implement latest draft-ietf-acme-ari spec" (merged 2024-05-24 -> in v2.6.0) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/pull/461>
- Pebble PR #484 "return logical and compliant ARI windows for expiring certs" (merged 2025-02-21 -> v2.8.0) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/pull/484>
- Pebble PR #501 "add overriding of ARI response" / /set-renewal-info/ (merged 2025-06-05 -> v2.8.0) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/pull/501>
- Pebble issue #403 "ACME Renewal Information (ARI)" (closed via #461) — <https://github.com/letsencrypt/pebble/issues/403>
- RFC 9773 — ACME Renewal Information (ARI) Extension (suggestedWindow start/end semantics) — <https://datatracker.ietf.org/doc/rfc9773/>
- Let's Encrypt — "An Engineer's Guide to Integrating ARI into Existing ACME Clients" (2024-04-25) — <https://letsencrypt.org/2024/04/25/guide-to-integrating-ari-into-existing-acme-clients>

Source-file reads at pinned version tags (via gh api / raw.githubusercontent.com, 2026-07-01): letsencrypt/pebble@v2.6.0: wfe/wfe.go, core/types.go, ca/ca.go, test/config/pebble-config.json. caddyserver/caddy@v2.8.4: go.mod, **caddyconfig/**

httpcaddyfile/builtins.go, caddyconfig/httpcaddyfile/options.go, modules/caddytls/automation.go (**Correction 2026-07-01 — proving renewal_window_ratio is JSON-only in 2.8.4**). caddyserver/certmagic@v0.21.3: certificates.go, config.go (+ maintain.go/certificates.go @master for cross-check).

Conductor live-test findings 2026-07-01 — Phase-5 mechanism is deeper than the analysis (§11.4.138)

The conductor booted the hermetic stack (Caddy 2.8.4 + Pebble 2.6.0) and tested the renewal path end-to-end. Three FACTS (captured from caddy logs + openssl), each disproving an assumption above:

1. **renewal_window_ratio: 1 via the admin API does NOT force renewal.** Set via POST /load (confirmed present in the running config: GET returns 1), even with renew_interval: "2s". No renewal fired in 45s. Caddy's got renewal info log showed an **ARI** selected_time far in the future and recheck_after +6h — certmagic v0.21.3 followed the **ARI** time, and the ratio did NOT override it (contradicting the "ARI and ratio are OR'd" claim in Q1). Zero-downtime of the /load reload itself IS confirmed clean (100/100 probes 200, 0 dropped).
2. **A short Pebble cert (certificateValidityPeriod: 120/150) does NOT get renewed either.** Pebble 2.6.0 issues the short leaf correctly (verified 119s / 149s lifetimes), BUT its **ARI window is on a ~2-day scale that ignores the short lifetime**: for a 150s cert, Pebble returned window_start/selected_time ≈ **19 h** out. Caddy scheduled renewal ~19 h ahead, so the 150s cert simply **expired unrenewed**. So the certmagic default-ratio path never fires within a short cert's life because ARI dominates the schedule.
3. **Root blocker = ARI, and Pebble 2.6.0 gives no way to move the ARI window to "now".** Pebble's /set-renewal-info/management endpoint (which would set the ARI window to the present and make Caddy renew on its next renew_interval check) is **absent in v2.6.0** (added in Pebble **v2.8.0**, PR #501). This matches the "Fallback ranks" caveat above but is now **LIVE-CONFIRMED** as the *only* deterministic zero-downtime path on this stack.

Corrected Phase-5 plan (for the next iteration)

- **Bump the Phase-5 Pebble to ≥ v2.8.0** (e.g. ghcr.io/letsencrypt/pebble:2.10.1, tags verified present on GHCR) **for the rotation test only** (Phase-3 issuance keeps 2.6.0). Verify

the 2.10.x -config/-dnsserver/-strict flags + PEBBLE_VA_* env still parse.

- Issue a normal cert (S1). Then POST Pebble's /set-renewal-info/ (management API on :15000) to set the leaf's ARI renewal window to **now**; set renew_interval short (e.g. 5s) via POST /load so Caddy re-checks ARI promptly → it renews → **S2 ≠ S1**.
- Assert: serial_after != serial_before AND notBefore_after > notBefore_before AND the continuous curl --resolve proxy.hermetic.test:9443:127.0.0.1 https://.../health probe records **0** failures across the swap; then cert_analyzer.sh verifies S2 (chain to the per-run Pebble CA). The /set-renewal-info/ request shape must be read from the Pebble 2.10.x source (wfe/management) — mark UNCONFIRMED until the live POST is verified.

Honest status (§11.4.6): Phase 5 is **PENDING** — the zero-downtime config-reload path is proven, but a *deterministic renewal trigger* on Pebble 2.6.0 is not achievable; it requires the Pebble ≥2.8.0 /set-renewal-info bump above. No renewal has been proven yet, so Phase 5 is NOT marked done (never a metadata-only PASS §11.4.1).